

Part III — The Bargain

WHY THIS PART — WHAT IS HAPPENING AND WHY

The shop of Madame Pace is named for the first time. The hundred francs. The pale blue envelope. The Father offers his great speech on the many-sided conscience: we are not one self but many, and to be caught in one moment is to be falsified by it. The Manager, who began this part still believing he was being held hostage by lunatics, begins instead to think there is a play in this — perhaps even one his contract should be wishing for. The bargain begins to be struck.

The Step-Daughter is sharp and unrelenting; every time the Father reaches for a beautiful word, she puts the literal fact next to it. The Father is in mid-flight. The Son is cold; he announces, without much ceremony, that he does not come into this drama, and that any attempt to make him come into it will fail. The Father describes how the drama ends — the death of the Child by the fountain, the tragedy of the Boy behind the trees, the flight of the Step-Daughter into the night. He describes it not as memory but as fact, already written, already inside him.

The Manager exits to his office with the Characters to organise the rehearsal. The Players are left on stage in a small chorus of bewilderment — the Door-keeper protesting he only let them in, the Property Man muttering that first the script made no sense and now the audience walks in off the street, the Prompter asking, in shorthand, in shorthand? The curtain falls on a theatre that has not yet decided whether it has been broken into or rescued.

THE SCRIPT, LINE BY LINE — WITH WHAT EACH LINE IS DOING

Appetite wins; he stops registering intrusion and starts smelling a season-filler, the commercial instinct drowning out any ethical pause.

THE MANAGER. There is something in what you say. I assure you all this interests me very much. I begin to think there's the stuff for a drama in all this, and not a bad drama either.

She steps forward to plant a flag: the drama lives in her, not the Father, and she wants that acknowledged before any deal is struck.

THE STEP-DAUGHTER [coming forward]. When you've got a character like me.

Panic beneath the snap — her bluntness could wreck the careful seduction he has been building, and he cannot afford it.

THE FATHER [shutting her up, all excited to learn the decision of the *Manager*]. You be quiet!

Already elsewhere, he is running sums and casting calls behind the ellipsis, the Characters' pain irrelevant to the calculation.

THE MANAGER [reflecting, heedless of interruption]. It's new... hem... yes...

A salesman's echo: he feeds the Manager his own word back to close the deal before doubt can reopen.

THE FATHER. Absolutely new!

Grudging admiration has already replaced resistance; the complaint is really a compliment, and both men know it.

THE MANAGER. You've got a nerve though, I must say, to come here and fling it at me like this...

Destiny, not desperation — he reaches for ontology to give the intrusion dignity and deflect the whiff of a pitch.

THE FATHER. You will understand, sir, born as we are for the stage...

Professional hierarchy deployed as a defensive wall: label them amateurs and the uncanny becomes merely impertinent.

THE MANAGER. Are you amateur actors then? Because we, sir, are a professional company, with a season to fill.

He starts the distinction that will expose the Manager's comfortable categories, then trails off, sensing philosophy is unwelcome here.

THE FATHER. No. I say born for the stage, because...

Flattery as interruption — the Manager buries the metaphysics under bonhomie before it can do real damage to the transaction.

THE MANAGER. Oh, nonsense. You're an old hand, you know.

He confesses his own theatricality and immediately weaponises the confession as proof of self-awareness, which is itself a performance.

THE FATHER. No sir, no. We act that rôle for which we have been cast, that rôle which we are given in life. And in my own case, passion itself, as usually happens, becomes a trifle theatrical when it is exalted.

Passing the creative burden to an absent author is a bid to stay administrative, clean-handed, and safely on the other side of the footlights.

THE MANAGER. Well, well, that will do. But you see, without an author... I could give you the address of an author if you like...

He blocks the escape route: complicity is the point, and a facilitator who feels no guilt is useless to him.

THE FATHER. No, no. Look here! You must be the author.

Genuine bewilderment, but short — the question already contains the hinge on which assent will turn.

THE MANAGER. I? What are you talking about?

Naked insistence strips the polite request away; he wants the Manager to feel chosen, even commanded.

THE FATHER. Yes, you, you! Why not?

A bureaucratic objection, not a moral one — he defines himself by job title, which is exactly the gap the Father will walk through.

THE MANAGER. Because I have never been an author: that's why.

Authorship flattered into a clerical act; devaluing the craft elevates the Manager's ego and dismantles his last excuse simultaneously.

THE FATHER. Then why not turn author now? Everybody does it. You don't want any special qualities. Your task is made much easier by the fact that we are all here alive before you...

Two words too brief to be conviction; the silence around them is already filling with capitulation.

THE MANAGER. It won't do.

Present tense is the trap — 'live,' not 'perform,' collapses the distance between their wound and his product.

THE FATHER. What? When you see us live our drama...

Craft invoked as a boundary: he can feel the pull but needs the alibi of a missing writer before he can say yes.

THE MANAGER. Yes, that's all right. But you want someone to write it.

Stenography, not authorship — strip the Manager of all creative risk and acceptance becomes frictionless.

THE FATHER. No, no. Someone to take it down, possibly, while we play it, scene by scene! It will be enough to sketch it out at first, and then try it over.

Almost, bit of an idea, might: the hedged language is a professional rationalising surrender as experiment, wanting permission from his own words.

THE MANAGER. Well... I am almost tempted. It's a bit of an idea. One might have a shot at it.

He moves to demonstration immediately, knowing that once a scene is witnessed it cannot be unseen or unfelt.

THE FATHER. Of course. You'll see what scenes will come out of it. I can give you one, at once...

Capitulation arrives wearing the mask of brisk decisiveness; the forgotten schedule proves the Characters have already taken over.

THE MANAGER *[he is hooked, in spite of himself; the schedule he came in trying to defend is no longer in his mind].* God help me, it tempts me. I'd like to have a go at it. Let's try it out. Come with me to my office. *[Turning to the Actors.]* You are at liberty for a bit, but don't step out of the theatre for long. In a quarter of an hour, twenty minutes, all back here again. *[To the Father.]* We'll see what can be done. Who knows if we don't get something really extraordinary out of it?

A question that is really an order — he ensures the whole world enters the room where the deal will be made.

THE FATHER. There's no doubt about it. They *[Indicating the Characters.]* had better come with us too, hadn't they?

His repeated 'come on' and the punctuality instruction show he has already mentally recast himself as director of their reality.

THE MANAGER. Yes, yes. Come on! come on! *[Moves away and then turning to the Actors.]* Be punctual, please! *[Manager and the Six Characters cross the stage and go off. The other Actors remain, looking at one another in astonishment.]*

Wounded vanity speaks first; 'furniture' is the word that gives away his fear — professional identity made irrelevant in seconds.

PLAYER 1. Is he serious? He has taken six strangers into his office and left us standing here like furniture.

A soft correction that signals unease more than insight; he senses something wrong but cannot yet name what it is.

PLAYER 3. They are not ordinary strangers.

What unsettles everyone gets its sharpest form here: these visitors arrived with catastrophe pre-formed, bypassing every normal theatrical process.

PLAYER 2. No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed.

Bitter sarcasm about the timeline collapses artistic ambition into a scheduling grievance; his real concern is not art but hours.

PLAYER 1. And now he wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

The anecdote positions the Manager as a reckless improviser, undermining his authority while appearing to supply a precedent.

PLAYER 2. He once staged the Nativity in fifteen.

Curiosity begins to crack the professional resentment; his tentative observation is the first fracture in the company's united front.

PLAYER 3. Perhaps there is a play.

Labour economics as self-protection — reduce everything to wages and the Characters' pain need not be felt at all.

PLAYER 2. There is always a play. The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it.

Comic because she has no idea she is already inside the drama the Characters carried in; the demand for a better part is the joke.

PLAYER 1 *[a line about vanity, delivered with no irony whatsoever].* I only know this: if the morning continues like this, I shall require a better part.

Two layers visible at once — cap in hand, Leading Man posture leaking through — the actor unable to fully disappear into a minor role.

PLAYER 1 *[the cap forgotten in his hand; Player 1's posture leaking through the doorman's apology].* I only let them in.

A crisp moral verdict dressed as a practical dismissal; she turns his admission into complicity in whatever comes next.

PLAYER 2. That is not a defence.

Their air of inevitability was so complete it overrode every professional instinct; the excuse is chilling precisely because it is true.

PLAYER 1. They looked expected.

Comic in timing, serious in implication — the boundary between performance and record has dissolved and nobody knows which side they stand on.

PLAYER 3. Am I taking this down?

Treating it as potential evidence is the moment the company stops watching a curiosity and starts fearing they are inside a consequence.

PLAYER 2. Take everything down. It may be evidence.

Thus talking, the **Actors** leave the stage; some going out by the little door at the back; others retiring to their dressing-rooms.